

Mithun Mohandas | mithun@digit.in

Q ASUS has always been known to cater to the enthusiasts from the very beginning. We know that the overclocking needs were fulfilled by ASUS at a time when none of the other vendors were pushing for it, thus fostering the Indian enthusiasts' scene. What is your opinion about the current enthusiasts' scene and also what are your experiences in the same domain in the last ten years? Where do you see it going?

Shetty: From the products perspective per se, this is not something we (ASUS) have been indigenously developing in India, it is something that has already happened worldwide. When attending global competitions for the enthusiasts, every name is present, however, Indian names would never show up. This led us to attempting to understand where the gap lies. Is it with the audience? No. The audience is present. There's a vast pool of brilliant minds. Next, we tried finding out from the Indian enthusiasts about what is lacking. We found that the hardware was an issue, this is an avenue where we could pitch in easily. This led to our first event for this hardware-deprived community about seven years ago. We started finding talented enthusiastic people, two of whom we sponsored to go to Taiwan during COMPUTEX and participate. Looking forward, there was a lull period, where everything settled down. We still have a list of enthusiasts that wish to come back. We're still digging into this. But now, the industry has diversified. We have overclockers, with their own follower base, a good amount of modders and now there are also, some gamers, who predominantly come from exchanging hardware. We realised that this is where the verticals have separated. So, we still continue encouraging the enthusiast scene.

Q With regards to industry reports, we keep hearing that the overall market of PCs are on a yearly decline of about 1-1.5%. But, the very same segment says that the enthusiasts segment is growing. Do you think it is reflecting the same statistics for markets like India?

Shetty: It is very similar. To be honest, when you talk about the Indian market, it was always a follower. If you separate



Understanding the nuances of the Indian PC market

Vinay Shetty,
Regional Director
for India & South
Asia, ASUS

We sit down with Vinay Shetty, Regional Director for India & South Asia, ASUS, to understand how ICT companies approach the Indian buyer

the PC market into entry, mid and high, the high-end is where the enthusiasts always found their space. The decline of the (PC) market happened in the entry-level, which used to be around 90%-95% of the market. This is my twenty-second year in this industry and I have seen this 95-97% drop down to 70%-80% now. The growth of the enthusiasts accounts for this 30%. Today, the entry-level PC includes smartphones and tabs, also PCs, at Rs. 10,000 you can even get a PC now. But the need for a good, powerful PC, segmented for designers, studios, high-end users and gamers, is still prevalent. That space is increasing. People today don't say they want a PC, they say that they want a gaming PC, a business PC, a Home Theatre PC and more. The classification is beautifully done. So, enthusiasts have grown and the PC market has declined.

Q Speaking of component sales, we see a lot of fluctuations in price where it is mostly a dealer-oriented market. With all the e-commerce platforms coming to the Indian market, do you see a shift from the small brick and mortar stores to e-commerce giants? Would you be selling directly on Amazon and Flipkart?

Shetty: The e-commerce craze has been going on since four-to-five years and it is becoming very strong. The component business, which you asked me about, is still controlled by the dealer market. We haven't signed up directly with any of the e-commerce sites. There are couple of reasons for the fluctuations in price, most of the dealers now have started to sell at that market place. They are also adapting to that move. But if parents or a student wants to buy a PC, they still go to a dealer. It is shrinking but it will never die, since they are also graduating them-